

Cohesive Devices in Personal and Interpersonal Correspondence

Introduction: The Glue That Holds Writing Together

Writing is more than arranging words on a page. Effective writing connects ideas in ways that readers can follow effortlessly. Poorly written communication, by contrast, confuses readers, obscures meaning, and often provokes unintended negative reactions.

Consider the difference between two versions of the same message. The first reads: *"We ordered items last week. They are not here. We are unhappy. Send them now. You should do better."* The second reads: *"I am writing to follow up on our order placed last week. As of today, we have not received the items, which is causing delays in our operations. We kindly request that you look into this matter immediately."* Both messages express frustration about a late delivery. One sounds demanding and unprofessional. The other sounds firm yet respectful. The difference lies largely in the use of **cohesive devices** — the words and phrases that connect sentences, show relationships between ideas, and guide readers through a message.

Beyond cohesive devices, effective written communication also requires attention to **audience**, **purpose**, **tone**, and **format**. A text message to a close friend differs from an email to a professor, which differs from a formal business letter. Each format has its own conventions, and each audience expects a different style of language.

This reading material examines the types of cohesive devices, the principles of personal and interpersonal correspondence, and the importance of adapting written communication to different audiences, purposes, and platforms.

Part 1: Cohesive Devices — Connecting Ideas Clearly

Cohesive devices are words or phrases that link sentences and paragraphs together, showing how ideas relate to one another. They function as the glue that holds writing together, preventing it from becoming a collection of disconnected statements.

Types of Cohesive Devices

Type	Function	Common Examples
Additive	Adds information or reinforces an idea	<i>and, also, moreover, furthermore, in addition, besides</i>
Adversative	Shows contrast or opposition	<i>but, however, yet, on the other hand, although, nevertheless</i>
Causal	Shows cause-and-effect relationships	<i>because, so, therefore, as a result, consequently, thus</i>
Temporal	Shows time sequence or order	<i>then, next, finally, meanwhile, subsequently, after that</i>
Referential	Refers back to previously mentioned ideas	<i>this, that, these, those, it, they, such, the former, the latter</i>
Conjunctive Adverbs	Transitions between complete thoughts	<i>however, therefore, thus, hence, nevertheless</i>

Examples in Context

Without cohesive devices:

"I studied for the exam. I passed. I did not understand everything. I got a good grade."

With cohesive devices:

"I studied for the exam, and I passed. However, I did not understand everything. Nevertheless, I still received a good grade."

The second version flows smoothly. The relationships between ideas — addition, contrast, and consequence — are explicitly signaled to the reader.

Ellipsis as a Cohesive Device

Ellipsis occurs when words are omitted from a sentence because they are understood from context. This avoids unnecessary repetition.

Example: *"She went to the store, and he did too."* (The words *"go to the store"* are omitted after *"did"* because they are understood.)

Example with ellipsis marked: *"I went to the park; she ____."* (The words *"went to the park"* are implied.)

Part 2: Personal and Interpersonal Correspondence

Correspondence refers to written communication exchanged between individuals or organizations. It can be divided into two broad categories: personal and interpersonal.

Personal Correspondence

Definition: Written communication focused on private, individual matters, typically between people who share a close relationship.

Characteristics:

- Informal or semi-formal tone
- First-person perspective common

- May include emotional expression
- Less rigid structure than formal correspondence

Examples:

- Personal letters to family or close friends
- Private journal entries
- Informal emails between acquaintances
- Personal social media posts

Interpersonal Correspondence

Definition: Written communication between individuals or groups, often in professional, academic, or formal social contexts.

Characteristics:

- Formal or professional tone
- Clear structure and purpose
- Attention to audience and hierarchy
- Politeness markers and respectful language

Examples:

- Emails to teachers or professors
- Business letters and official correspondence
- Job application letters and cover letters
- Professional social media posts (LinkedIn, professional forums)

Key Differences

Feature	Personal Correspondence	Interpersonal Correspondence
Tone	Informal, casual, warm	Formal, respectful, measured
Audience	Friends, family, trusted individuals	Teachers, employers, colleagues, officials
Structure	Flexible, may be loose	Standardized, follows conventions
Language	Colloquial, contractions, emotional	Standard, precise, professional
Cohesive devices	Simpler connectors (and, so, but, then)	Varied, sophisticated (moreover, however, consequently, nevertheless)

Part 3: Formats of Correspondence

Different communication platforms and purposes require different formats. Understanding these formats ensures messages are appropriate for their intended audience.

Formal Letters

Purpose: Official requests, complaints, applications, or formal notifications

Key structural elements:

- Sender's address and date
- Recipient's name and address
- Formal salutation (*Dear Sir/Madam*, or *Dear Dr. Reyes*,)
- Clear subject line
- Organized body paragraphs

- Formal closing (*Sincerely, Respectfully, Yours faithfully*)
- Signature line with printed name

Example:

text

March 15, 2025

The Principal
St. Helena High School
Cityville, Metro

Dear Sir/Madam,

I am writing to request permission to be excused from class on March 20, 2025, due to a scheduled medical appointment. I will ensure to catch up on any lessons or assignments missed during my absence.

Thank you for your understanding.

Sincerely,
Angela Marie Dela Cruz
Grade 11 - St. Teresa

Formal Emails

Purpose: Professional or academic communication

Key structural elements:

- Clear, specific subject line
- Appropriate salutation (*Dear Mr. Santiago,*)
- Concise body organized into short paragraphs
- Polite closing (*Best regards, Sincerely, Thank you*)
- Signature with full name and relevant information

Example:

text

Subject: Request for Extension on Project Submission

Dear Mr. Santiago,

Good day! I hope you are doing well.

I am writing to kindly request a two-day extension for the submission of our science project due to unexpected internet connectivity issues at home. I assure you that I will submit the final output by Friday.

Thank you for your understanding and consideration.

Best regards,

Kristine D. Ramos

Grade 11 - St. Dominic

Social Media Posts

Purpose: Informative, persuasive, or reflective communication for public or semi-public audiences

Types of social media posts:

Type	Purpose	Tone	Example
Informative	Share announcements or reminders	Neutral, professional	*"Reminder: Parent-Teacher Conferences will be held on Friday from 1:00 PM to 4:00 PM at the gymnasium."*
Persuasive	Encourage action or change	Enthusiastic, compelling	<i>"Vote for Team Aspire! We stand for transparency, action, and student empowerment."</i>
Reflective	Share personal	Thoughtful,	<i>"This week taught me that asking</i>

Type	Purpose	Tone	Example
	insights	vulnerable	<i>for help is not a weakness. Grateful for those who remind me to keep going."</i>

Part 4: Adapting Language to Audience and Purpose

Effective written communication requires deliberate choices based on who will read the message and why.

Considering the Audience

Audience	Appropriate Language	Inappropriate Language
Teacher or professor	Formal, respectful, complete sentences	Slang, text abbreviations, overly casual tone
Close friend	Informal, conversational, may include humor	Overly formal or stiff language
Employer or supervisor	Professional, polite, concise	Complaints without solutions, emotional outbursts
Stranger or official	Courteous, clear, structured	Demanding tone, missing context, unclear requests

Considering the Purpose

Purpose	Appropriate Tone	Language Features
To inform	Neutral, factual	Clear subject line, direct statements, logical organization
To request	Polite, respectful	Politeness markers (<i>could you, I would appreciate, kindly</i>)
To complain	Firm but respectful	Specific details of the issue, requested resolution, calm tone
To apologize	Sincere, accountable	Acknowledgment of the mistake, expression of regret, plan to address
To persuade	Enthusiastic, confident	Strong openings, evidence, calls to action

Considering Cohesive Devices by Context

Context	Appropriate Cohesive Devices
Formal letter or email	<i>however, therefore, furthermore, consequently, nevertheless</i>
Personal letter to a friend	<i>and, so, but, then, also, because</i>
Social media post (informative)	<i>first, next, finally, for example</i>
Social media post (reflective)	<i>but, yet, although, so</i>

Part 5: Common Errors and How to Avoid Them

Error 1: Overly Casual Language in Formal Correspondence

Problem: Using slang, contractions, or text-speak in emails to teachers or employers.

Example of error: *"Hey Prof, I can't make it to class. Stuff came up. Hope that's cool."*

Corrected version: *"Dear Professor Reyes, I regret to inform you that I will be unable to attend class today due to unforeseen circumstances. I will obtain notes from a classmate and complete any missed assignments. Thank you for your understanding."*

Error 2: Missing or Incorrect Cohesive Devices

Problem: Sentences that do not connect logically, forcing the reader to infer relationships.

Example of error: *"The project was difficult. We finished early. Everyone was surprised."*

Corrected version: *"Although the project was difficult, we finished early. Consequently, everyone was surprised."*

Error 3: Ignoring the Audience

Problem: Writing the same way regardless of who will read the message.

Example of error (email to a principal): *"Hey, can I get out of class early on Friday? Got a thing. Thanks!"*

Corrected version: *"Dear Principal Santos, I am writing to request permission to be excused from class at 2:00 PM on Friday, March 21, due to a family commitment. I will ensure that all assignments are completed before my departure. Thank you for your consideration."*

Error 4: Inconsistent Tone

Problem: Shifting between formal and informal language within a single message.

Example of error: *"Dear Sir, I am writing to request an extension. Also, thanks a bunch for understanding. Sincerely, John."*

Corrected version: *"Dear Sir, I am writing to respectfully request an extension. I appreciate your consideration of this matter. Sincerely, John."*

Part 6: Practical Application — Revising for Clarity and Coherence

The following examples demonstrate how revising with attention to cohesive devices, audience, and purpose transforms unclear writing into effective communication.

Example 1: Text Message to a Friend

Original (choppy, disconnected):

"Hey. I didn't go. Traffic. No mood. Just stayed home."

Revised (clear, connected):

"Hey! I didn't go to the party because the traffic was terrible, and I wasn't in the mood anymore. So, I just stayed home instead."

Cohesive devices added: *because, and, so, instead*

Example 2: Email to a Professor Requesting an Extension

Original (too casual, unclear):

"Hi. I can't submit. Things came up. Hope it's okay."

Revised (formal, clear, respectful):

"Dear Professor Santos, I hope this message finds you well. I am writing to request an extension for my paper due to unforeseen personal circumstances. I understand the

importance of deadlines; however, I would appreciate your consideration. Thank you very much."

Cohesive devices added: *I hope, I am writing to, due to, however, I would appreciate*

Example 3: Apology to a Group Chat

Original (lacks connection):

"Sorry I missed the meeting. I overslept. I had a long night."

Revised (smoother, accountable):

"I am really sorry I missed the meeting earlier. I had a long night working on the proposal, and unfortunately, I ended up oversleeping this morning. I will catch up with the notes and updates."

Cohesive devices added: *earlier, and, unfortunately, this morning, substitution (the meeting)*

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Cohesive Devices	Words or phrases that link sentences and paragraphs, showing relationships between ideas
Additive Devices	Cohesive devices that add information (<i>and, also, moreover, furthermore</i>)
Adversative Devices	Cohesive devices that show contrast (<i>but, however, yet, nevertheless</i>)
Causal Devices	Cohesive devices that show cause and effect (<i>because, therefore, as a result</i>)
Temporal Devices	Cohesive devices that show time sequence (<i>then, next, finally, meanwhile</i>)

Term	Definition
Referential Devices	Words that refer back to previously mentioned ideas (<i>this, that, it, they</i>)
Ellipsis	Omission of words understood from context, avoiding unnecessary repetition
Personal Correspondence	Written communication focused on private matters, typically informal in tone
Interpersonal Correspondence	Written communication in professional, academic, or formal social contexts

Review Questions

Responses should be written on a separate sheet of paper.

1. Define **cohesive devices** in your own words. Why are they essential for clear writing?
2. Identify the type of cohesive device (additive, adversative, causal, temporal, referential) used in each sentence:
 - *"The restaurant was fully booked. Consequently, we decided to order takeout instead."*
 - *"John loves playing the guitar. He practices every day."*
 - *"I wanted to attend the concert; however, I had already committed to another event."*
3. A student writes to a principal requesting permission for a school event. Which of the following would be **inappropriate** for this correspondence, and why?
 - *"Hey, we need the gym for Friday. Hope that's cool."*
 - *"Dear Principal Cruz, we respectfully request permission to use the gymnasium this Friday for a student council event."*
4. Rewrite the following poorly written email to a teacher, adding at least three cohesive devices and adjusting the tone to be appropriate for the audience:
"Hi. I missed class. Can I get the notes? Thanks."
5. Explain the difference between **personal** and **interpersonal** correspondence. Provide one example of each.

